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Graduate Recruitment Team
Columbia Threadneedle Investments
Cannon Place, 78 Cannon Street
London EC4N 6AG

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am applying for the Investments Graduate Programme (Leadership Development Programme) in London. I am a final-year Economics student at the University of Strathclyde, graduating in summer 2027 with a predicted 2:1. Columbia Threadneedle's Investments Graduate programme, rotating through equity and fixed income research, portfolio management and trading over 24 months, is one of the broadest starts in asset management.

My academic work centres on a question asset managers answer every day: what is a return worth once its risk is understood? I tested CAPM on 694 anomaly portfolios across 54 countries and found it fails jointly in 48 of 53, with momentum and value earning the most persistent alphas. My dissertation, supervised by Dr Luigi Gifuni, asks whether governments that hedge oil change how their currencies react to OPEC news, through Norway's krone conversions, Russia's 2017–22 budget rule and Mexico's put hedge, and whether any oil risk that remains is worth trading after costs, a question that matters to any portfolio with commodity or currency exposure.

Asset management appeals to me because it rewards a process that holds up over years rather than a single good call, and because the money belongs to people relying on that process. As co-founder of the Strathclyde Agricapital Society, which I grew to 126 members, I led weekly research sessions on transactions such as Olam Agri's USD 1.24bn stake sale to SALIC and published weekly research notes for members from outside finance. That work taught me that a sound view is only half the job; it also has to be explained clearly to the people who rely on it.

Columbia Threadneedle stands out to me because its graduate rotations cover research, portfolio management and trading, and its trainees join a network of around 250 peers through Investment20/20, which suits someone who wants to understand the whole investment process before specialising. My CAPM research and my dissertation's work on currency and commodity risk have prepared me for the research rotations, and I would like to see how those ideas are tested inside a global fund manager.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Will McGowan